

BRAVE & STRONG

An Anxiety Workbook for Kids Ages 6-12

You are braver than you think!

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A MESSAGE FOR PARENTS & CAREGIVERS

This workbook uses CBT (Cognitive Behavioral Therapy) principles adapted for children. It teaches kids to:

- Understand what anxiety is (normalizing it)
- Identify their worries and triggers
- Challenge anxious thoughts with evidence
- Face fears gradually (exposure therapy)
- Build a toolkit of calming strategies

HOW TO USE: Work through pages together or let your child work independently. Go at their pace. Celebrate all brave steps!

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WHAT IS ANXIETY?

Anxiety is your brain's ALARM SYSTEM. It's supposed to keep you safe.

But sometimes the alarm goes off when there's NO real danger.

It's like a smoke alarm going off because of toast - not a fire!

When I feel anxious, my body might:

- ☐ Tummy hurts or feels funny
- ☐ Heart beats really fast
- ☐ Hands get sweaty
- ☐ Hard to breathe
- ☐ Feel dizzy
- ☐ Want to run away or hide
- ☐ Can't stop thinking scary thoughts

Circle the ones YOU feel! It's totally normal.

MY WORRY MONSTERS

Let's give your worries a name! When we name them, they lose power.

Worry Monster #1:

Name: _____ What it says to me:

Draw it here:



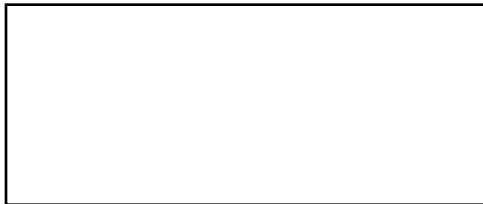
How big is this worry? (circle)

TINY SMALL MEDIUM BIG HUGE

Worry Monster #2:

Name: _____ What it says to me:

Draw it here:



How big is this worry? (circle)

TINY SMALL MEDIUM BIG HUGE

Worry Monster #3:

Name: _____ What it says to me:

Draw it here:



How big is this worry? (circle)

TINY SMALL MEDIUM BIG HUGE

THE ANXIETY TRICK

Here's a SECRET about anxiety:

The more you AVOID something scary, the SCARIER it gets!

It's like a bully. If you run away, it chases you harder.

But if you face it (a little bit at a time), it gets SMALLER.

EXAMPLE:

Sarah was scared of dogs. She avoided ALL dogs.

Her fear got BIGGER and BIGGER.

Then she tried her BRAVE LADDER:

Step 1: Look at pictures of dogs

Step 2: Watch dogs from far away

Step 3: Be near a small, calm dog

Step 4: Pet a friendly dog

Each step felt scary at first, but her brain LEARNED it was safe!

MY BRAVE LADDER

Write your fear at the top. Break it into small steps from easy to hard:

My fear: _____

Step 7: _____

Scariness (1-10): ____ Done? [☐]

Step 6: _____

Scariness (1-10): ____ Done? [☐]

Step 5: _____

Scariness (1-10): ____ Done? [☐]

Step 4: _____

Scariness (1-10): ____ Done? [☐]

Step 3: _____

Scariness (1-10): ____ Done? [☐]

Step 2: _____

Scariness (1-10): ____ Done? [☐]

Step 1: _____

Scariness (1-10): ____ Done? [☐]

Remember: Start at the bottom! You don't have to rush to the top.

CALM-DOWN BREATHING EXERCISES

BALLOON BREATH:

1. Put your hands on your tummy
2. Breathe IN slowly - blow up the balloon in your tummy!
3. Breathe OUT slowly - let the air out of the balloon
4. Do this 5 times. Your body will calm down!

STAR BREATH:

1. Hold up your hand like a star
2. With your other finger, trace UP each finger = breathe IN
3. Trace DOWN each finger = breathe OUT
4. By the time you finish all 5 fingers, you'll feel calmer!

HOT CHOCOLATE BREATH:

Pretend you're holding a cup of hot chocolate.

Smell the yummy chocolate (breathe IN through nose)

Cool it down (breathe OUT through mouth slowly)

THINKING TRAPS

Sometimes our brains trick us into thinking the WORST will happen.

These are called THINKING TRAPS:

THE DISASTER TRAP:

Thinking the WORST thing will definitely happen.

'If I raise my hand, everyone will laugh at me and I'll die of embarrassment!'

THE ALL-OR-NOTHING TRAP:

Everything is either PERFECT or TERRIBLE.

'If I'm not the best at soccer, I'm the worst player ever!'

THE MIND-READING TRAP:

Thinking you know what others think.

'That kid didn't wave back - they must HATE me!'

THE FORTUNE-TELLING TRAP:

Predicting bad things will happen.

'I KNOW the test will be impossible and I'll fail!'

BRAVE THOUGHTS PRACTICE

Situation: Going to a birthday party

Worry thought: What if nobody talks to me?

Brave thought: I've been to parties before and had fun. If I feel nervous, I can find one person to talk to.

NOW YOUR TURN! Think of a time you felt this way:

My situation: _____

My worry thought: _____

Evidence it's NOT true: _____

My BRAVE thought: _____

Scariness BEFORE brave thought (1-10): ____

Scariness AFTER brave thought (1-10): ____

BRAVE THOUGHTS PRACTICE

Situation: Taking a test at school

Worry thought: I'm going to fail and everyone will think I'm dumb!

Brave thought: I studied. Even if I don't get 100%, I'll do my best. One test doesn't make me dumb.

NOW YOUR TURN! Think of a time you felt this way:

My situation: _____

My worry thought: _____

Evidence it's NOT true: _____

My BRAVE thought: _____

Scariness BEFORE brave thought (1-10): ____

Scariness AFTER brave thought (1-10): ____

BRAVE THOUGHTS PRACTICE

Situation: Sleeping alone at night

Worry thought: Something scary might happen in the dark!

Brave thought: My room is safe. My parents are right here. Nothing bad has happened before.

NOW YOUR TURN! Think of a time you felt this way:

My situation: _____

My worry thought: _____

Evidence it's NOT true: _____

My BRAVE thought: _____

Scariness BEFORE brave thought (1-10): ____

Scariness AFTER brave thought (1-10): ____

BRAVE THOUGHTS PRACTICE

Situation: Trying something new

Worry thought: I'll mess up and everyone will laugh!

Brave thought: Everyone messes up when they're learning. That's how we get better!

NOW YOUR TURN! Think of a time you felt this way:

My situation: _____

My worry thought: _____

Evidence it's NOT true: _____

My BRAVE thought: _____

Scariness BEFORE brave thought (1-10): ____

Scariness AFTER brave thought (1-10): ____

BRAVE THOUGHTS PRACTICE

Situation: Being away from parents

Worry thought: What if something bad happens to them?

Brave thought: My parents are safe. They always come back. Worrying doesn't keep them safer.

NOW YOUR TURN! Think of a time you felt this way:

My situation: _____

My worry thought: _____

Evidence it's NOT true: _____

My BRAVE thought: _____

Scariness BEFORE brave thought (1-10): ____

Scariness AFTER brave thought (1-10): ____

MY CALM-DOWN TOOLKIT

When I feel anxious, these things help me calm down:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____

Draw your happy/calm place here:



WORRY TIME BOX

You get 10 minutes of 'Worry Time' each day. That's it!

If a worry comes at other times, write it down and save it for Worry Time.

My Worry Time is at: _____ (same time every day)

WORRIES I'M SAVING FOR WORRY TIME:

When Worry Time is over, I close the box and go do something fun!

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 1

Brave Challenge #1

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #2

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 2

Brave Challenge #3

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #4

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 3

Brave Challenge #5

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #6

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 4

Brave Challenge #7

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #8

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 5

Brave Challenge #9

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #10

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 6

Brave Challenge #11

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #12

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 7

Brave Challenge #13

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #14

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 8

Brave Challenge #15

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #16

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 9

Brave Challenge #17

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #18

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

BRAVE CHALLENGES LOG - Page 10

Brave Challenge #19

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

Brave Challenge #20

Date: _____ What I faced: _____

How scared I was before (1-10): ____

How scared I was during (1-10): ____

How scared I was after (1-10): ____

What actually happened: _____

Was it as bad as I thought? YES / NO

I am BRAVE because: _____

CERTIFICATE OF BRAVERY

This certifies that

has shown incredible courage by
facing their fears and doing hard things!

You are BRAVE. You are STRONG.
You are more powerful than your worries!

Date: _____

Signed: _____

PARENT GUIDE

HOW TO SUPPORT YOUR ANXIOUS CHILD:

- Validate their feelings: 'I can see you're scared. That's okay.'
- Don't accommodate avoidance - gently encourage facing fears
- Model brave behavior and coping out loud
- Praise EFFORT, not just outcomes ('You tried! That's so brave!')
- Don't promise 'nothing bad will happen' - teach them they can COPE
- Keep your own anxiety in check (they mirror you)
- Celebrate small victories - every brave step matters
- Seek professional help if anxiety interferes with daily life

WHEN TO SEEK PROFESSIONAL HELP:

- Refuses to go to school
- Can't sleep alone for weeks
- Physical symptoms interfere with activities
- Extreme tantrums around feared situations
- Anxiety is getting worse, not better